

Table 3.1 Ten Question Overconfidence Test

	Low	High	Units
Martin Luther King's age at death	_____	_____	
Length of Nile River	_____	_____	Miles
Number of countries that are members of OPEC	_____	_____	
Number of books in the Old Testament	_____	_____	
Diameter of the moon	_____	_____	Miles
Weight of an empty Boeing 747	_____	_____	Pounds
Year in which Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart was born	_____	_____	
Gestation period (in days) of an Asian elephant	_____	_____	
Air distance from London to Tokyo	_____	_____	Miles
Deepest (known) point in the oceans	_____	_____	Feet

If you are like most people who play this game, you are reliably overconfident. Wes has collected ad-hoc experimental evidence on around 2,000 subjects who have taken this questionnaire. He finds that individuals typically get 30 percent correct, when a well-calibrated individual should, on average, get 90 percent correct, consistent with the 90 percent confidence interval. This low-scoring result holds even when Wes warns test-takers that prior test-takers have been systematically overconfident in their upper and lower bounds. Wes then encourages them to increase the bounds of their ranges. Of course, nobody listens, and on average, only three-tenths of the correct answers actually sit within the individual's confidence range. We are hard-wired to be overconfident.⁸

A common example of such overconfidence used to occur in the office when talking about sports. Jack is the resident sports expert. He is an avid fan of most sports and can easily recall random statistics for many teams and players. However, in the past, Jack used to be very certain about the outcome of games, and would let everyone know. But a funny thing happened to our “expert” when we began measuring his success rate: It was not as high as his confidence! Over the years (especially as we were writing this book), he learned to limit his “guarantees” with regard to the outcome of sporting events. While we all have some topic that we follow all the time